MYPRIVACYTOOL · TELEGRAM PRIVACY GUIDE

Your Telegram privacy settings: a 5-minute guide

The self-check asked about eight settings in your own Telegram account. This guide walks through each one: where to find it, what to choose, and what you give up. Most take under a minute.

You don’t need to delete your account or stop using Telegram. Most of what other people can see about you is controlled by a setting you can change today.

How to use this guide

- Open Telegram and go to **Settings**, then **Privacy and Security**. Nearly everything below is in there.
- Work through the eight settings in order. Anything you already had right, skip.
- Menu names can differ a little between iPhone, Android and desktop, and between app versions. If a name doesn’t match, look for the closest one nearby.

The eight settings at a glance

#	Setting	Choose
1	Two-step verification	On, with a recovery email
2	Active sessions (logged-in devices)	End any you don’t recognise
3	Phone number	Hidden from non-contacts, and not findable by number
4	Profile photo	My Contacts
5	Last seen & online	My Contacts or Nobody
6	Who can add you to groups	My Contacts
7	Forwarded messages	Nobody (no link to your profile)
8	Contact syncing	Off, and delete what’s already uploaded

Protect the account itself

1. Turn on two-step verification

`Settings > Privacy and Security > Two-Step Verification`

Choose: set a password and add a recovery email.

Why: a login code sent by SMS is no longer enough to take over your account. Someone would also need this password.

Watch out: use an email address you can still open. If you forget the password, that email is how you reset it.

2. Check your active sessions

`Settings > Devices (older versions: Privacy and Security > Active Sessions)`

Do: read the list of logged-in devices. Tap any you don't recognise and end the session.

Why: an old or unknown login can read your chats. If your phone was ever lost or stolen, do this first.

Repeat: every few months, and after you change phones.

Control what strangers can learn about you

3. Hide your phone number, and stop people finding you by it

`Settings > Privacy and Security > Phone Number`

Choose: under "Who can see my phone number", pick **My Contacts** or **Nobody**. Under "Who can find me by my number", pick **My Contacts**.

Why: your number is the easiest thing to link your account to the real you. Without this, anyone with your number can search for your account.

Trade-off: anyone who already has your number saved can still see it, and new contacts must find you by username instead.

4. Limit who can see your profile photo

`Settings > Privacy and Security > Profile Photos`

Choose: My Contacts (or Nobody, with exceptions for people you add).

Why: a photo is a quick way to match a Telegram account to a person on other sites.

5. Hide when you were last online

`Settings > Privacy and Security > Last Seen & Online`

Choose: My Contacts or **Nobody**.

Why: last-seen times show when you sleep, travel and are active.

Trade-off: Telegram works both ways. If you hide yours, you generally see only approximate “last seen recently” for others.

6. Choose who can add you to groups

`Settings > Privacy and Security > Groups & Channels (older versions: Groups)`

Choose: My Contacts.

Why: stops strangers placing you in groups you didn’t choose, which is a common route for spam and scams.

7. Stop forwarded messages linking to your profile

`Settings > Privacy and Security > Forwarded Messages`

Choose: Nobody.

Why: when someone forwards something you wrote, it shows your display name as plain text instead of a link to your profile.

8. Turn off contact syncing, and delete what was uploaded

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Settings > Privacy and Security > Data Settings (on some versions: Contacts) > Sync Contacts / Delete Synced Contacts
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Choose: switch **Sync Contacts** off, then use **Delete Synced Contacts**.

Why: syncing uploads your address book to Telegram, so it can link you to people who have your number.

Trade-off: Telegram will stop suggesting people you know. You can still add contacts by hand.

> **Test it.** After you change these, ask one friend or family member to confirm they can still message you. If someone you want to hear from can’t reach you, loosen the phone-number or groups setting for them.

What these settings can’t do

- They control what **other Telegram users** can see. They don’t remove your details from sites outside Telegram.
- They can’t hide your account from Telegram itself.
- People who already have your number or username saved keep what they have.

If you want to check beyond Telegram

Your phone number and email can also show up on other sites. MyPrivacyTOOL’s free scan shows what your browser and devices reveal about you.

> Run the free scan at **myprivacytool.io/scan**.

Quick checklist

☐ Two-step verification on, recovery email I can open
☐ Active sessions reviewed, unknown ones ended
☐ Phone number hidden; not findable by number
☐ Profile photo: My Contacts
☐ Last seen & online: My Contacts or Nobody
☐ Groups: My Contacts
☐ Forwarded messages: Nobody
☐ Contact syncing off, synced contacts deleted

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